

John W. Z. Zhang

✉ w.zhang59@lse.ac.uk 🔗 wzhangjohn.github.io in

Education

Stanford University <i>Visiting Student Researcher</i>	<i>Autumn 2026</i>
○ Sponsor: Prof. Gary Cox.	
London School of Economics and Political Science <i>PhD in Economic History</i>	<i>Sep 2023 – Autumn 2026</i>
○ Fields: Economic History, Political Economy. ○ Supervisors: Prof. Patrick Wallis and Prof. Mohamed Saleh. ○ Teaching Assistance: Theories and Evidence in Economic History; The Family Economy in History.	
London School of Economics and Political Science <i>MSc in Economic History</i>	<i>Sep 2022 – Nov 2023</i>
○ Graduated with Merit (70.88%). ○ Dissertation ranked 2nd in the cohort (out of 100+).	
University of Bath <i>BSc (Hons) Economics</i>	<i>Sep 2019 – Jul 2022</i>
○ Graduated with First-class honours. ○ Dissertation ranked 1st in the cohort (out of 300+).	

Job Market Paper

Welfare Retrenchment and Social Unrest 🔗	2026
<i>Abstract:</i> Does welfare retrenchment cause social unrest? I study this question using parish-level expenditure on poor relief and data on social unrest in post-Napoleonic England, drawing on the 1818-9 welfare reforms to motivate instrumental variables, regression discontinuity, and event study research designs. The reduced-form analysis finds a causal effect of welfare retrenchment on social unrest between 1816 and 1834, attributable to an exacerbation of relative deprivation that stems from comparisons with higher-expenditure parishes. Simulations from a counterfactual analysis assuming greater accountability for these grievances highlight the importance of equitable social welfare provision in minimising the political costs of austerity.	

Working Papers

Deskilling and Unrest 🔗	2026
Endogenous Revolutionary Threat 🔗	2026

Next Release

Austerity Origins of the Great Reform Act	2026
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Dataset

Egyptian Parliamentary Speeches, 1924-1952 (with Mohamed Saleh) 🔗	2025
<i>Methods:</i> Computer Vision; Generative AI.	

Presentations

- 2026:** Economic History Association Annual Meeting, St. Louis; Western Economic Association International Annual Conference, Denver; Workshop in Political Economy and Economic History, York; Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy, London; Frontier Research in Economic and Social History Workshop, Berlin; Economic History Society Annual Conference, London; Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2025:** PPE for Public Policy Graduate Conference, London; Graduate Seminar in Economic and Social History, University of Oxford; Economic and Social History Workshop, University of Cambridge; Graduate Economic History Seminar, London School of Economics and Political Science.
- 2024:** Seminar for Political Economy and Economic History, London School of Economics and Political Science.

Other Credentials

Languages: English and Mandarin.

Technical Skills: Julia, MATLAB, Python, QGIS, R and Stata.